

Well, it seems to me that one can ask oneself a series of questions along the following lines. What type of system is compatible with something that:

a. Produces a nice replica of a cobra and mongoose when printed out on a cartesian xy graph.

b. Creates the sequence JKEO on the top row of a railfence three after a Caesar three-shift on VIG O.

c. Breaks into a 16 block design which after, as requested, performing a reverse VIC Cipher cut can then be sequenced to match, perfectly A-to-Z, a 21 column transposition sequence based on the key phrase JOHNFITZGERALDKENNEDY.

d. Where the result of c. can be fed into a 17 column transposition based on the key phrase JOHNKENNEDYLANCER, and the output of that fed into a 7 column transposition based on the keyword KRYPTOS with the result being, among other things, that the lower left hand corner spells JK (or is that Jo Ke without the vowels?) in two directions.

e. or which, alternatively, can be first fed into a 17 column transposition matrix based on the keyphrase JOHNKENNEDYLANCER, then into a 21 column matrix based on the keyphrase JOHNFITZGERALDKENNEDY, and then into a 7 column matrix based on KRYPTOS and obtain output which 1.) in the top row spells out BBQ (the first three letters of the BB QQ SS SS ZZ TT signal group). 2.) in the upper right hand corner spells WZW, and right below that ZW, interpretable as a friendly invitation to run a railfence in two directions, and when converted to numbers based on a straddling checkerboard based on the keyword KRYPTOS, ZW produces 96 97 in that same corner. This being also the final four block sizes in a sequence reversed in the four-by-four block transposition matrix resulting from the reverse VIC cut referred to above. 3.) in the bottom two rows in columns labeled 473 produces, in interlocking triangle form, the initials JFK, JKL and JKT, believed to represent John Fitzgerald Kennedy, John Kennedy Lancer, and John Kennedy Toole, the author of *A Confederacy of Dunces*, along with an interesting, but not necessarily printable, whole bottom row where yet another vowel could potentially have been "palimpsested", and 4.) when such triangle shapes are applied to the upper left hand corner the text BBQ BED BGS emerges from the mist.

f. It must not be forgotten that although position 17 in K1 spells JK, many of the clues used, and much of the story told, comes from clever hints to shape K4 text into a diamond anchored by WW (provides the interlocking JKL, JFK, JKT, not to mention an invitation, via listing its left side in the same area of the lower part of the diamond, perhaps to use a straddling checkerboard based on the keyphrase JOHNFITZGERALDKY, for example). Other hints from the signal group invites to shape a 7 by 14 matrix with a "confirmed" signal being the Q-codes QSJ QSS appearing in both vertical and horizontal directions. This impressive matrix provides not only the instructions for the VIC cipher cut mentioned above (to cut K4 in the middle and place the second half first), and hints at the ID BY ROWS/LAYER TWO area by listing WJ...ETG, but also links JKL with ADUL (Allen Dulles), creates a great replica of an OSS Spearhead in which a triple JS points to WDUL (perhaps fingering Allen Welsh Dulles-not alone in that), a double linked LO LO, a VIGO, links the sequences LOSW (Lee Oswald perhaps?) and BLU BLU (Bluebird perhaps?), YAT (a New Orleans dialect prominently figuring in JKTs *A Confederacy of Dunces* and notorious for shortening sentences by cutting out letters, particularly vowels), and JKT.

g. We probably also need to consider that K4 not only has a graph of a cobra, it starts with a suggestive anagram of one too, OBKRU. A pretty clear alphabet decimation hint is included in RUX (letters 4,5 and 7) SOLIF. RUX FILOS are sequences that are obtained from vertical ABC DEF GHI JKL (hey! that's in Layer Two on a Trifid, for ex.) MNO PRS TUV WXY Z, and leaving out Q (otherwise the decimation sequence is RUX FILOR). Group old timers may recall that we ran this on a trifid on Berlin and got NY in positions 1 and 2 a couple of years ago. Some who are really old may recognize it from the signals plan in the old NSA top cryptanalyst course AC-400.

So yes, it would need to be compatible with all that. Not to prejudice anyone's own theories of course, but the implication seemingly being that an enormous flexibility would be needed in the selection and positioning of the letters in the text as we know it. (Not to mention a significant ability to work out ahead of time how these letters would move in a multitude of very complicated directions. But then again after spending a couple of hours designing K1 and K2, Mr. Scheidt would have tinkered with K3 for a while, mainly so that the transpositions produced sequences like EN DYHR OHN, YAR To RAY in actual ray form, etc. otherwise that would have just taken another hour. Whereupon he would have had nearly all of another four months to accomplish the K4 feats.) Do you think that a system exists that can accomplish yet another feat like that? Or is that John Kennedy Toole hint the final message from WW?

Incidentally, rumors of departmental infighting within the CIA has reached me. Could such a thing be happening? Well, apparently they are arguing about the cobra and the mongoose.

The clandestine service, I am told, is totally on board with the cobra and mongoose design and there is an uptick in the requests for assignments to India, a sharp increase in requests among the ops for reading materials about exciting codes and ciphers in famous Indian literature, great interest in message K2, and disappointment that K2 is actually in Pakistan. They also see great potential in a new cipher system they call Playback which will allow them to flexibly interpret encrypted messages from management, and stick it to The Man. Meanwhile, Counterintelligence is spreading a rumor that it is not a cobra and mongoose at all, but actually a mole, cowering in front of a lasso (an age-old counterintelligence tool) while the Office of Security, not to be outdone, is arguing it is a sharp eyed ferret studying a particularly worrisome polygraph readout. Both these latter departments are thinking about launching investigations, of course - what else is new, but prefer for now at least to focus on the animal's tail. That would never have worked back in the day, when Jim A. in CI instantly would have gone for the full mongoose numerology as an initial, conservative, estimate.

Naturally, the system and its output should also be compatible with the answer Jim Sanborn apparently once gave in an interview when asked the question what he would do if K4 was deciphered. According to a friend of mine his answer was something like "probably head for the hills."

Now this leaves me in a slight quandry (sic), because I can either spend the evening taking another close look at the Aryabhata Cipher, which is very interesting, as is a lot of Aryabhata's work, and other Indian stuff, or I can head uptown and see the play Indian Ink again. Well it's a pretty good show with some mysteries, just like Kryptos, but it has one other significant advantage. Romula Garai is in it, does a good job, **and** part of the time she is not wearing anything at all. I'm outta here.....